two Indian monarchs to be considered ‘Great’, was his determination, in a complex and complicated land, to negotiate a place of dignity for each person and every creed through the idea of sulh kul. ‘He was a prince beloved of all, firm with the great, kind to those of low estate,’ wrote Monserrate, ‘and just to all men, high and low, neighbour or stranger, Christian, (Muslim) or (Hindu); so that every man believed that the King was on his side.’

The only other Indian emperor to command such widespread acclaim is Ashoka, of the third-century bce Maurya dynasty, with whom Akbar shares a number of intriguing similarities. Both men were third in the line of their dynasties, and both were remarkably successful warriors and leaders, conquering vast swathes of the subcontinent through personal bravery and able generalship. Both men had to overcome personal and political obstacles in the early years of their kingship, before they settled on ways of being and ruling that would be praised for millennia. And both men experienced an epiphany that would mark them for the rest of their lives. While any detailed comparison between these two monarchs is necessarily limited by the eighteen centuries between them, it is evident that both men strove to rule their empires justly and well during their long reigns, emphasizing the rational over blind superstition, and moved by an enormous spirit of compassion. And what has endured through the vaulting centuries is Ashoka’s clearly enunciated humanity and remarkable notion of respect for all faiths and all religions, not simply as a passive act of tolerance but as a ‘public culture in which every sect honours every other’ by learning and respecting one another,[*] — traits that are mirrored almost exactly by Akbar.

The central beliefs of Ashoka and Akbar continue to be relevant today. India is a uniquely diverse and complicated country made even more tangled by a bloody and vicious post-colonial legacy. A profoundly disturbing trend today is the attempt to try and rectify perceived wrongs by ’revising’ and ‘reinterpreting’ the past and its legacies, and to formulate an increasingly narrow definition of ‘Indianness’. It is perhaps inevitable that people in each age are in search of certitudes. But the essential truths about people and societies, whether in India or elsewhere, are intricate, messy and often impenetrable. They cannot be made to conform to any particular ideological persuasion, no matter how strident the argument becomes. Our very DNA refuses to be categorized into one geographical location, or